

Lesson Plan: How to Use AI to Build a Better Democracy

Introduction [5 min]

- This is neither a pro-AI nor an anti-AI event
- The technology is going to happen, and there is a lot of negativity around it, this is our attempt to turn it into a force for good; Darth Vader & Luke Skywalker *both* used the force

We will focus on how to strengthen democracy with these tools:

- **Find the moments when participation matters** — uncover upcoming hearings, votes, public-comment periods, rulemakings, and other decision points.
- **Hold power accountable** — investigate government actions, trace decisions, compare promises with outcomes, and uncover information that is difficult to find.
- **Turn concern into action** — identify concrete actions that target the people and institutions with the power to make a difference.
- **Lower the barriers to civic participation** — give ordinary people research and analytical capabilities that once required significant time, expertise, or institutional resources.

Quick poll [5 min]

1. How well do you think you understand AI technology? (hold up your fingers 1-5)
2. How many people think AI is a danger to humanity?
3. How many of you use AI? (do I need to do a tutorial decision point)
 - a. How many of you know how to get online and use AI?
4. How many of you use AI to learn things?
5. How many of you think there should be more laws about how AI is used or the development of AI?

Today we're going to be diving into how AI can help ordinary people exercise *more* democratic power. [3 min]

- What happens when ordinary people suddenly have access to tools for understanding, organizing and exercising power that previously belonged primarily to institutions and people with money?
- What happens when complex opaque bureaucracy becomes transparent?
- What happens when the money trails are surfaced?
- What happens when campaign promises are compared to voting and legislation records?

Let's talk about AI

Some practical things to keep in mind as we go through these exercises [5 min]

- AI can be wrong. Ask it to “not make anything up” or “confirm all information”. It is important to double check the information you get.
- The responses you receive depend on the prompts you compose.
- Ask AI to distinguish between facts, predictions, assumptions, and opinions.
- Ask “What are you uncertain about?” or “What part of this answer should I independently verify?”
- Ask it to “Explain this to a non-expert” or “use simple English”.
- Don't put highly sensitive personal information into a prompt.
- Treat AI as a research and thinking tool, not the final authority.

Quick tutorial on how to access AI [5 min]

- Check if everyone has used AI before. If not, have non-AI users pair up with AI users
- Get everyone set up using AI
- Review ChatGPT v Claude v Gemini etc
- Phone vs laptop

Break-out activities [1 hour]

1. Break-out into small groups
 - a. Number off

- b. You'll have access to all of the exercises on the website afterwards, so can do the other exercises on your own later

Topics for Break out groups

1. [Be a better voter](#) : Learn how AI can clarify the impact of complicated ballot measures.
2. [How to use AI to shape AI](#): Learn how to use AI to shape AI regulation.
3. [Shape Federal Policy Before It's Final](#): Learn how you make a public comment on federal regulation changes.
4. [Turn outrage into action](#): Learn how to take action on something that makes you angry and use AI to figure out what you can do about it.
5. [Go beyond elections](#): Learn *when* your participation could actually matter—not just when an election happens.
6. [Development vs the Environment - Prop 45](#): Learn how to use AI to understand trade-offs and power dynamics.
7. [Follow the Money: Who Funded the insurance commissioner candidates?](#) Learn how funding can highlight private interests and how candidates might behave if elected.

Group discussion [20 min]

1. Have one person from each group share:
 - a. The exercise they went through
 - b. Key take-aways
 - c. Was using the AI useful?
 - d. Anything else?
1. Discuss as a group
 - a. What were your major takeaways from this session?
 - b. Will you use some of these techniques in the future?
 - c. Do you think this is worth sharing?

Conclusion [10 min]

I hope this gives you a better understanding of what AI can actually do in the democratic process and how we can use it as a tool for good. How it can not only help you be a better voter but show you how to have a voice beyond just voting. My next project is going to be building some agents to perform specific political activities, like watchdog activities, commenting opportunities etc. If anyone is interested in helping me build this then let me know. And remember-the question isn't simply whether AI is *good or bad for democracy*. It's who gets to wield it, for what purpose, and whether we can deliberately build AI that redistributes democratic capacity toward citizens.